

Chapter 39: The Point Where It Starts to Hurt

Jenny should have expected it.

That was what she told herself later.

But expectation and reality never arrived at the same time.

Austin didn't come that morning.

Or the next.

Or the day after that.

At first, she didn't react.

Not properly.

She worked.

She cleaned.

She served.

She smiled when she needed to.

She functioned.

That was what she called it.

Functioning.

By the second day, Bao stopped teasing her.

That alone was suspicious.

By the third day, he stopped pretending not to notice.

"You're doing it again," he said quietly.

Jenny didn't look up.

"I'm working."

"No," Bao said.

"You're waiting."

That word landed wrong.

Jenny frowned.

"I'm not waiting for anything."

Bao didn't argue.

He just said,

"That's not what your eyes are doing."

That made her stop.

Just for a second.

Then she continued wiping the counter.

Harder than necessary.

At night, the apartment felt louder.

Not in sound.

In absence.

Jenny sat by the window again.

Phone in hand.

No message.

No explanation.

No "busy today."

Just silence.

She unlocked her phone.

Stared at it.

Locked it again.

Then unlocked it again.

Ridiculous.

Completely ridiculous.

She wasn't that kind of person.

She didn't wait for people.

She didn't—

Her thoughts stopped there.

Because she realized she already was.

On the fourth day, something shifted.

Not externally.

Internally.

She stopped pretending she wasn't checking the door.

She stopped pretending she wasn't listening for footsteps.

She stopped pretending she didn't notice every unfamiliar movement in the restaurant.

And that was worse.

Because awareness made everything sharper.

On the fifth day, she finally said it out loud.

"He hasn't come."

Bao didn't respond immediately.

Then softly,

"No."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not normal."

Bao shrugged.

"For him, maybe it is."

That didn't help.

It made it worse.

On the sixth day, she caught herself standing at table seven.

Empty.

Of course it was empty.

It had been empty for days.

But she stood there anyway.

Like her body remembered something her mind refused to accept.

"You look angry," Bao said behind her.

Jenny didn't turn.

"I'm not angry."

"You are."

A pause.

Then softer—

"You're hurt."

That word hit differently.

Jenny finally turned.

"I'm not—"

But she stopped.

Because denying it felt useless now.

Even to herself.

That evening, her phone finally buzzed.

She grabbed it too quickly.

Too desperately.

She hated that she did.

A message.

Austin.

We need to talk.

Three words.

That was all.

No greeting.

No warmth.

No explanation.

Jenny stared at it.

For a long time.

Then she typed:

About what?

She waited.

Nothing.

Minutes passed.

Still nothing.

That silence did something worse than absence ever did.

It created distance again.

But this time...

it didn't feel like routine distance.

It felt like consequence.

Later that night, a second message arrived.

I'll come tomorrow.

Jenny read it once.

Then again.

Then locked her phone without replying.

She sat by the window in the dark.

The city outside moved like nothing had changed.

But inside her chest...

something already had.

Because she finally understood what she had been avoiding for days.

Austin wasn't just absent.

He had stepped out of reach.

And for the first time since meeting him...

she didn't know if "coming back" would mean the same thing anymore.